A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada

His Divine Grace A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada · @bhaktivedanta-svami

The Founder-Acharya

His Divine Grace A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami was a disciple of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati and the founder-acharya of the International Society for Krishna Consciousness (ISKCON); his followers call him Srila Prabhupada. One of the biographies glorifies him as a rasika-acharya — a teacher who knows the taste of pure devotion just as Sri Chaitanya gave it to the world. Such a gift is rare, and the biographer recalls the words of the "Srimad-Bhagavatam": "Among many millions of the liberated and the perfected, O great sage, a peaceful devotee of Narayana is rarely found". (Srimad-Bhagavatam, 6.14.5)

His whole life grew out of a single command. In 1922, at their very first meeting, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta told him to preach the teaching of Sri Chaitanya throughout the world; forty-three years later, at nearly seventy, the disciple sailed for America alone, without money or companions, to carry that command out.

Childhood and Youth

Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami appeared in this world on 1 September 1896 in Calcutta — on Nandotsava, the day after Janmashtami[1]. The boy was named Abhay Charan De. His father, Gour Mohan De, and his mother were Vaishnavas who worshipped Krishna. His father's house, as Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled, stood on "Hazen Road", in one of the best quarters of the city.

Following Bengali custom, the parents called an astrologer to cast the child's horoscope. Among other things he foretold that when the boy reached seventy he would cross the ocean, become a great preacher and open a hundred and eight temples. The book "Our Teachers", published by our mission, says that this prediction came true in full.

Abhay grew up in Vedic culture, and from the age of about six he was already serving the Deities of Sri Radha and Sri Krishna himself. When the time came for study, his father sent him to the Scottish Church College in Calcutta. The times were troubled: Hindus and Muslims were at odds, the movement for independence from Britain was gaining strength, and the college schooled young men in Western ways, its professors often disparaging the ancient culture of India without any ground. Abhay, raised in a Vaishnava family, saw the narrowness of such an education, yet he went on studying because his family wished it.

Absorbed in his studies, he gave up the worship, and the Deities were put away in a box for a time. Then Krishna appeared to him in a dream and asked: "Why have you put Me in a box? Why do you not worship Me?" Abhay returned to his service. Many years later he wrote to one of his disciples: "There has never been a moment in my life when I did not remember Krishna. I have always known Him, from my very birth."

While still a student Abhay was married; the match was arranged by his father. Like many of his generation he answered Mahatma Gandhi's call: in 1920 he sat the examinations of his fourth year and, in protest, refused his diploma. What drew him to Gandhi was the conviction that spiritual values must rule the life of society, together with loyalty to the Vedic tradition. He then entered the service of Dr. Kartik Chandra Bose, a well-known Calcutta surgeon and pharmaceutical manufacturer; but the work occupied his thoughts far less than his spiritual search.

Meeting His Guru

Abhay first heard of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati in 1922. He had seen many sadhus — his father welcomed them warmly into his home — but some of those meetings had brought him nothing but disappointment. So when a friend invited him to a festival of the Gaudiya Math to meet the Math's acharya, Abhay was sceptical; still, the friend persuaded him.

The first words they heard from Srila Bhaktisiddhanta were a call: "You are educated young men. You must preach the teaching of Lord Sri Chaitanya throughout the world." That meeting turned Abhay's life around.

He put a pointed question: who would listen to such preaching while India was a dependent country? Should not independence come first? Srila Bhaktisiddhanta answered: "Krishna consciousness does not depend on who is in power. Humanity needs it so badly that we have no right to wait until India gains independence." Every government is temporary, he explained; Krishna consciousness alone is eternal, and a person's true self is the soul. Then he quoted in Sanskrit the verse of the "Bhagavad-gita" in which the Lord calls on us to give up all other duties and surrender to Him alone (by its sense, 18.66).

The guru, "Our Teachers" observes, is not an external authority or an office-holder to be obeyed blindly: he gives convincing answers to spiritual questions and dispels doubts, and by hearing him a sincere disciple is freed from every obstacle on the path. So it was with Abhay. Later he recalled that on that evening he had, in essence, accepted Srila Bhaktisiddhanta as his guru: "Not formally," he would say, "but in my heart. I understood that I had met a real saint."

The business of the pharmaceutical firm took Abhay and his family to Allahabad (Prayaga). There he rented a house and a small shop and sold Dr. Bose's products; Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled that Jawaharlal Nehru and Indira Gandhi used to come to him as customers. In 1928 Bhakti Pradipa Tirtha, one of the leading sannyasis of the Gaudiya Math, opened a branch of the mission in Allahabad and asked Abhay for financial help. He gave it gladly and often invited the devotees of the Math to his home.

"Our Teachers" calls Gour Mohan De a great Vaishnava. Before his departure in 1930 he asked his son to support the preaching of the Gaudiya Math in every way and to do all he could for Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's disciples. Abhay loved his father dearly and fulfilled his wish.

In 1932 Abhay received initiation from Srila Bhaktisiddhanta — harinama and the gayatri mantra on the same day; he had been recommended to the guru by Srila B. K. Tapasvi Maharaj. He still remained a family man and travelled on the business of a pharmaceutical firm. He wished to become rich, but only so as to serve his guru's mission with money. He could not travel with Srila Bhaktisiddhanta or see him often, yet he planned his journeys so as to be in Calcutta whenever his guru was there. The thirty years he was still to spend in India are the story of a single desire that grew stronger in him year by year: to fulfil his guru's will and preach Krishna consciousness throughout the world.

A Godbrother

Abhay first met Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj in 1930 in Allahabad. Sridhar Maharaj had not yet taken sannyasa: he had left home and come to Allahabad as a vanaprastha, dressed in white. More than forty years later, at the opening of the temple in Mayapur in 1973, Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami recalled those days: "Krishna and Prabhupada [Srila Bhaktisiddhanta] chose him to prepare me. Sridhar Maharaj lived in my house for many years, and naturally our relations were most intimate. I have always taken his instructions and advice very seriously, because I see in him a pure devotee. I sought his company and tried to help him. We are very close spiritually."

Though they were Godbrothers, he always addressed Sridhar Maharaj as “Your Divine Grace” and “Om Vishnupad”, as one addresses only one’s guru. In this, “Our Teachers” says, lies the whole essence of their lila: he went beyond etiquette, and such regard for a Godbrother has no precedent. For more than five years they kept close company, often for five to seven hours a day, and he was sure that it was Sridhar Maharaj who had prepared him for preaching in the West. Many other disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta also regarded Sridhar Maharaj as their shiksha-guru — Bhakti Prajnana Keshava, Bhakti Saranga Goswami, Bhakti Dayita Madhava, Bhakti Pramoda Puri.

Sridhar Maharaj himself told of one of their talks. It concerned the verse of the “Bhagavad-gita” in which Krishna speaks of the souls surrendered to Him: “dadami buddhi-yogam tam yena mam upayanti te” — “I give them the inner divine inspiration that helps them come close to Me” (10.10). Sridhar Maharaj remarked that the word “upayanti” here points to parakiya-rasa, and his companion agreed: “Yes, what is meant here is precisely the parakiya-rasa of Vraja. Nothing else can be the highest conclusion of the ‘Bhagavad-gita’.” Another time Sridhar Maharaj asked what he thought of his reading of several verses of the “Gita” in the light of madhura-rasa, and heard: “What can I say? Your interpretation is absolutely correct.”

They preached together, too. Abhay, then still a householder, opened an office in Bombay for his business; together with Sridhar Maharaj he opened a temple of the Gaudiya Math there, and they formed two parties to collect donations. One was made up of himself, Sridhar Maharaj and Bhakti Saranga Goswami; they called on his pharmacist acquaintances and collected about five thousand rupees. “I made the introductions,” he recalled, “Sridhar Maharaj preached, and Goswami Maharaj collected the donations.”

Satsvarupa Dasa Goswami, one of his disciples, writes in his biography that Abhay often accompanied Sridhar Maharaj and his assistants and played the mridanga at their programmes, and when Sridhar Maharaj was ill he led the party himself: he led the kirtan, played the mridanga and lectured on the “Srimad-Bhagavatam”. He acknowledged Sridhar Maharaj as “a pure Vaishnava, a pure devotee”, greatly valued his advice and discussed with him even what spiritual benefit his failures in business and the discord in his family were bringing him.

Abhay always helped Sridhar Maharaj’s preaching and highly prized his rare gift for bringing out the very essence of the scriptures. When Sridhar Maharaj compiled the book “Sri Sri Prapanna-jivanamritam” — a collection of Sanskrit verses, his own and those of devotees of the past, on the six limbs of sharanagati, full surrender to Krishna — Abhay took the cost of publishing it upon himself. Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled how he said to his sister Bhavini Didi, whom the Math called Pishima: “‘Sri Sri Prapanna-jivanamritam’ is a much-needed and wonderful book. You have money. Please help to publish this book.” And it was she who gave the money for the first edition.

Once in Bombay the two of them arranged a meeting with a sannyasi of the Gaudiya Math who had returned from Europe. He came without his tridanda, without a shikha and without sannyasi dress, and said of the West: “They asked such questions as cannot be answered.” Abhay began to draw out of him what the questions were, and Sridhar Maharaj answered them one after another. Then Abhay declared: “Today Asia has conquered Europe!”

“Print Books”

One of his most important meetings with his guru took place in Vrindavana in 1935. Abhay was walking with Srila Bhaktisiddhanta and several Godbrothers along the bank of Radha-kunda, and the guru shared his sorrow with him: some of his senior disciples were quarrelling over the rooms and property of the Calcutta Math — what would happen when he was gone? (Abhay himself took no part in

those quarrels.) This “fire of factional interests”, once it flared up, would destroy everything. “It would be good,” he said, “to take the marble off the temples and print books with the money.” And, turning directly to him, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta said: “If you ever have money, print books.” Abhay felt that these words had changed the course of his life.

For Srila Bhaktisiddhanta’s Vyasa-puja of 1936 Abhay offered his guru a poem and an essay, and read them at a gathering of his Godbrothers in Bombay. Both were received very warmly and printed in the journal “Harmonist”. The essay amazed many devotees of the Math: this little-known Bengali so deeply understood the siddhanta of the Gaudiya Vaishnavas and the position of the guru. His thought runs thus: whoever interprets the divine sound, shabda-brahma, by his own imperfect perception, without being trained under a genuine acharya, inevitably deviates from Vyasadeva, as the Mayavadis do, and cannot be a guru. He quoted the verse of the “Padma Purana”: “sampradaya-vihina ye mantras te nishphala matah” — a mantra received outside the disciplic succession is fruitless. “We cannot know anything of the transcendental region by our limited, perverted method of observation and experiment”; it can only be heard — “the transcendental sound transmitted from that region to this, through the unadulterated medium of sri gurudeva or Sri Vyasadeva.” And therefore, he concluded, “we should surrender ourselves today at the feet of the representative of Sri Vyasadeva for the elimination of all our differences bred by our unsubmissive attitude.”

An excerpt of this address — Abhay delivered it on behalf of the members of the Bombay branch of the Gaudiya Math and signed it “Abhay Charan Das, For Members, Sri Gaudiya Math, Bombay” — half a century later became the preface to Srila Sridhar Maharaj’s book “Sri Guru and His Grace”. “Sixty-two years ago, on this auspicious day,” he said, “the acharyadeva made his appearance by the call of Thakur Bhaktivinoda at Sri Ksetra, Jagannatha Dhama at Puri”; and to honour him is no sectarian concern: “There is only one guru, who appears in an infinity of forms to teach you, me and all others.” Srila Bhaktisiddhanta is not the guru of a sectarian institution but “the jagad-guru, or the guru of all of us: the only difference is that some obey him wholeheartedly, while others do not obey him directly.” He is “the tenth disciplic representative from Sri Rupa Goswami”, and his advent day is honoured as Sri Vyasa-puja, “because the acharya is the living representative of Vyasadeva”. He is “our ‘eye-opener,’ our eternal father, our eternal preceptor and our eternal guide.” And for himself Abhay prayed to bear the lot due to his past misdoings, but to keep “this power of recollection: that I am nothing but a tiny servant of the Almighty Absolute Godhead, realized through the unflinching mercy of my divine master.” “In ten short years, Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada inundated the world with Krishna Consciousness,” write the compilers of the book; in this address “he smashes the sectarian misconception that the spiritual master is limited to a particular person, form, or institution, and establishes the universal conception of guru.”

One of his Godbrothers nicknamed Abhay “kavi”, “poet-sage”, and the name stuck. But what mattered more was that Srila Bhaktisiddhanta read the poem. It struck at the very spearhead of his preaching, aimed against impersonalism, and it gave him great joy; the editor of the “Harmonist” received the order: “Print whatever he writes.” Abhay later revealed his philosophical and literary gift in full: in a short time he produced more than sixty books on Vaishnava philosophy — a feat of service to his guru.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta left this world in January 1937. A month earlier Abhay wrote to him that, being a family man, he could not give all his time to service, and asked: “Could you not give me some definite service?” Two weeks later the answer came: “I am quite sure that, knowing English, you will be able to convey our ideas to people who do not know the languages [Bengali and Hindi]… This will bring good both to you and to your listeners. I very much hope that you will be able to preach successfully in English.” Abhay took this letter as a confirmation of the command of 1922, and from then on he had no doubt about the purpose of his life.

Before his departure Srila Bhaktisiddhanta charged his senior disciples to continue the preaching in the West. He had sent his first envoys to London in his lifetime, but his departure and the Second World War that soon followed cut short what had been begun. Among the great Vaishnavas whom Srila Bhaktisiddhanta trained, "Our Teachers" names Srila Sridhar Maharaj, Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami, Bhakti Prajnana Keshava, Bhakti Vilasa Tirtha, Bhakti Dayita Madhava, Bhakti Pramoda Puri, Bhakti Saranga Goswami and many others; but, the book says, only one of them succeeded in fully carrying out his wish for the West — Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami.

"Back to Godhead"

Carrying out his guru's command, Abhay began writing commentaries on the "Bhagavad-gita", and then conceived the idea of publishing at his own expense a journal, "Back to Godhead", on the philosophy of the Gaudiya Vaishnavas. He thought out, wrote and typed its articles himself, alone, in his flat. He was living in Calcutta then and rented two houses on Sitakanta Banerjee Lane: in one lived his family, in the other was his pharmaceutical laboratory. The upper rooms of the laboratory he gave to his dear Godbrother Sridhar Maharaj and his disciples — among them the young Gaurendu Brahmachari, the future Srila Govinda Maharaj. Thus Sridhar Maharaj's Calcutta centre was housed in his home for many years[2].

"Guru Maharaj told me to study the 'Srimad Bhagavad-gita' under Srila Swami Maharaj at the times when he himself was away from Calcutta," Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled. Abhay brought out two or three issues of the journal, but there were no funds to go on; huge stacks lay in his room, and no one offered to distribute them. Then he said to Gaurendu: "Take the journal and distribute it, going from door to door." "So I became the first distributor of that journal," Srila Govinda Maharaj related. "I did not know a word of English, but I was very proud of the chance to distribute that journal." Even then, in Calcutta, Abhay at once saw unusual spiritual qualities in the youth.

In those same years he was translating the "Bhagavad-gita" into English and writing a commentary on it, discussing it with Sridhar Maharaj. "When Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada began his translation of the 'Bhagavad-gita', he consulted me on many points," Sridhar Maharaj said in March 1982. It was an enormous labour, but the manuscript was burnt through an employee's carelessness, and in America he had to translate the "Gita" and write the commentary all over again.

The times were hard: India had lived through the Second World War, the post-war crisis and partition into two states. Educated people and officials took almost no interest in the journal. Abhay himself went to the press to read the proofs, himself printed the journal and himself distributed it. He also tried to found a "League of Devotees" — the forerunner of the future International Society for Krishna Consciousness — and grew ever more convinced that only a spiritual revival could lead civilisation out of its crisis.

Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled that they lived then in Abhay's house among Hindus, while right next door the Muslim houses began. Clashes raged nearby, and at night bandits attacked homes. Abhay was much alarmed and once told Gaurendu that bottles of incendiary mixture were kept in the attic: if they were attacked, he was to throw them at the attackers. "Such were the conditions we lived in then, but afterwards, by the Lord's mercy, it all came to an end."

Starting the preaching was not easy. "Since he was a grihastha at that time, a family man, and I was a brahmachari in saffron," Srila Govinda Maharaj related, "he taught me a few shlokas from the 'Srimad-Bhagavatam' and at public lectures gave me the vyasasana (the seat of honour of the speaker). 'Recite these verses,' he would say, 'and then I will explain them to the audience.' That is how he began his preaching. His eagerness to spread Krishna consciousness was immense."

Vrindavana and Sannyasa

The years went by. His children grew up and became independent, and the pharmaceutical business, once profitable, declined. His senior Godbrothers told Abhay that in this way the Lord, by His mercy, was freeing him from worldly ties so that he could give his whole life to the service of Krishna. By 1950 he had withdrawn from business, handing it over to his sons, and settled in Vrindavana, in the temple of Sri Sri Radha-Damodara, whose Deity Srila Rupa Gosvami had revealed[3]. Here he began the chief work of his life — an English translation, with commentary, of the many-volumed "Srimad-Bhagavatam", eighteen thousand verses. He chose the "Bhagavatam" as the most important and authoritative Vaishnava scripture: he needed books for preaching, and he wanted not only to publish them but to bring them to the West.

The title "Bhaktivedanta", later known throughout the world, was given to Abhay Charan De by Srila Sridhar Maharaj. After Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's departure the Gaudiya Math split into several missions, and many senior Vaishnavas took shelter of Sridhar Maharaj. People came to him for advice on difficult questions; almost all the senior disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta took sannyasa from him, and others asked him from whom they should take it. So Abhay Charan Prabhu, too, turned to Sridhar Maharaj — and received the name "Bhaktivedanta".

In 1959 he was given sannyasa by Sripad Bhakti Prajnana Keshava Maharaj, one of the senior disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta and the first sannyasa disciple of Sridhar Maharaj. He kept for him the title "Bhaktivedanta" and gave him the name "Swami". So Srila A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami began his great service.

The Only Passenger of the "Jaladuta"

Shortly before his departure he asked Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha to come with him to America; but that devotee, secretary of the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math, was serving his guru and humbly declined.

On 13 August 1965, a few days before his sixty-ninth birthday, Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami sailed for America to open the teaching of Sri Chaitanya to the people of the West. Sumati Morarji, owner of the Scindia shipping company, was on friendly terms with him, and he was taken as the only passenger on a small cargo ship, the "Jaladuta". With him he had a suitcase, an umbrella, a little grain, forty rupees — about seven dollars — a few books, and faith in the mercy of his guru. Among the books were the "Srimad-Bhagavatam" and Sridhar Maharaj's "Sri Sri Prapanna-jivanamritam".

The voyage proved very hard. A few days out the ship ran into violent storms; besides seasickness, the Swami suffered two heart attacks, and on the next two nights the attacks returned, so that he understood this journey might cost him his life. On the third night Krishna Himself came to him in a dream, encouraged him and promised him full protection. There were no more attacks.

On Friday, 10 September 1965, he wrote in his diary: "Today the ship is not rolling, and I feel somewhat better. But I feel the pain of separation from Vrindavana and my Lords: Sri Govinda, Gopinatha and Radha-Damodara. My only consolation is the 'Chaitanya-charitamrita', reading which I relish the nectar of Lord Chaitanya's lila. I have left Bharata-bhumi only to fulfil the desire of Sri Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, in which the will of Lord Chaitanya is expressed. Having none of the needed qualifications, I am nevertheless taking the risk, wishing to carry out the order of His Divine Grace. Being far from Vrindavana, I depend only on Their mercy."

Three days later he wrote a prayer to Krishna. You have brought me here, he says, so You must have some business here. The people here are in the grip of passion and ignorance, content with their lives and indifferent to the message of Vasudeva; but by Your causeless mercy even the impossible becomes possible, and only Your will can free them from illusion. The words of the "Srimad-Bhagavatam" are

Your incarnation, and humble hearing of the “Bhagavatam” purifies the heart: here he quotes the verses of the “Bhagavatam” (1.2.17–21) on how hearing and service to a pure devotee drive passion, ignorance and lust out of the heart. I myself am unfortunate and fallen, he goes on, and I can convince them only with Your blessing; success or failure is in Your will. And further: “O Lord, I am a puppet in Your hands. And since You have brought me here to dance, then make me dance, make me dance, O Lord, make me dance as You wish. I have neither devotion nor knowledge, but I have firm faith in the Holy Name of Krishna. I have been named Bhaktivedanta, and now, if You wish, You will help me to justify the true meaning of that name.”

The voyage lasted thirty-seven days. He arrived in America utterly alone: all his property was what he had taken on board — no money, no friends, no followers. But he firmly believed that by the mercy of the Lord and his guru he would fulfil his mission. He himself said that he came to America “as an aggressor” — to challenge illusion.

New York: The Birth of ISKCON

In September 1965 he came to New York, and for a whole year he struggled alone to found a movement. He lived very simply and spoke about Krishna at every opportunity; little by little he managed to interest a few people. His first winter in the West, that of 1965–1966, was the hardest. He went on translating and thought about how to open a temple of Krishna in New York.

Then he moved to the Lower East Side of Manhattan, renting an apartment and a small shop, “Matchless Gifts”, with a shop-window on Second Avenue, number 26. Word spread among young seekers of truth that an Indian swami had come who taught a “special process of yoga” — the chanting of the Hare Krishna mantra — and people began coming to see him and ask questions. The Lower East Side was then the centre of the hippies: in 1966 thousands of young people wandered its streets in search of the meaning of life. He was given a task which, in the words of “Our Teachers”, no teacher before him had known — to transplant Vedic culture into the most unsuitable soil; and it was these young people who were destined to become his flock.

Soon he registered the International Society for Krishna Consciousness — ISKCON — of which he had dreamt while still in India. The words “Krishna consciousness” are his rendering of the phrase “krishna-bhakti-rasa-bhavita” from Srila Rupa Gosvami’s “Padyavali”. Krishnadasa Kaviraja quotes this verse as well: “krishna-bhakti-rasa-bhavita matih / kriyatam yadi kuto ’pi labhyate…” — “The sweetness of bhakti, in the unfolding of an individual relationship with Krishna, cannot be attained even by performing pious deeds for millions of births in a row. Only one thing is needed — an ardent desire to obtain without delay such unalloyed devotion, wherever it may be manifest.” (CC, Madhya 8.70) Thus Mahaprabhu’s living teaching received the name by which the whole world came to know it. The premises the Swami rented with the help of his first followers came to be called the “temple”.

When registering the Society in 1966 he set out its seven purposes, and in them, “Our Teachers” says, one sees how clearly he foresaw the future scope of the movement. The Society was to bring spiritual knowledge to people systematically and teach them spiritual practice, so as to restore the balance of values in society, unite people and establish peace; to preach Krishna consciousness as it is set forth in the “Bhagavad-gita” and the “Srimad-Bhagavatam”; to bring its members closer to one another and to Krishna, helping each to realise that every soul is an inseparable part of Krishna; to spread sankirtana, the congregational chanting of the Holy Name, according to the instructions of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu; to build, in one of the holy places of Krishna’s pastimes, a city for its members and for all people; to unite its members into one family and teach them a simple, natural way of life; and for all this to publish journals and books.

Preaching Is the Essence

“Books are the basis, practicality is the principle, preaching is the essence, and purity is the strength,” Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami used to say. From his very first days in America he returned to “Back to Godhead”, but now he entrusted the journal to his first disciples: they wrote the articles themselves, typeset, edited, printed and distributed it. The preaching was still his own, but he was no longer alone.

In January 1967 a temple of Sri Sri Radha-Krishna opened in San Francisco, and a few months later the Swami himself installed there the Deities of Lord Jagannatha, Subhadra and Balarama. That summer his health forced him into a clinic for urgent treatment. As soon as he had recovered, he decided to visit India and took his first Western disciples with him — he lovingly called them his “dancing white elephants”. Before he left, his disciples told him they meant to open centres in Boston, Buffalo, Santa Fe and Los Angeles, and he was delighted. “The Hare Krishna mantra is like a big cannon,” he said. “Fire it so that everyone hears, and maya will flee the battlefield in fear.”

On that journey, at the invitation of the custodians of Uddharana Datta’s temple in Saptagram, he went there with his American disciples. The whole suvarna-vanik community honours this temple, and as a child he had visited it with his parents; he tells of this himself in his commentary on the “Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Adi 11.41). Of other days of the same journey — in Navadvipa, with Sridhar Maharaj — we shall speak below.

Meanwhile six American devotees set out to open a centre in London. The first months were hard; then they met George Harrison of the Beatles, and with his help recorded a disc of the Hare Krishna mantra at the Apple studio. By the time the Swami arrived in London, John Lennon and Yoko Ono had given the devotees part of their house.

From 1965 to 1970 he worked above all to strengthen the Society in America: if Americans accepted the philosophy of Krishna consciousness, he reasoned, the whole world would follow. In India his preaching had no success — his countrymen did not take Krishna consciousness seriously. Following the mood of his guru, he applied to the full the principle of yukta-vairagya given by Srila Rupa Gosvami: to accept everything favourable to the service of Krishna and reject everything unfavourable. He boldly put Western technology, capital and learning to the service of preaching — both in the West and in India itself, where he developed the holy places revered by the Gaudiya Vaishnavas. To this end he resolved to build three large temples in India: in Vrindavana, in Mayapur and in Bombay.

For twelve years, until his very departure, he travelled the world: fourteen times he circled the globe, personally guiding his growing movement. In those years he brought Krishna consciousness to almost every major city of the world, created a society of thousands of members and opened a hundred and eight temples on five continents — so the astrologer’s prediction made at his birth came true as well. He transplanted into foreign soil what many had thought to be merely an Indian faith, and showed in practice that the teaching of the Gaudiya Vaishnavas belongs to no single culture: it is the soul’s own dharma, the eternal nature of everyone. Mahaprabhu’s living teaching, to which he gave the name “Krishna consciousness”, he carried farther than the Gaudiya thinkers of his time had thought possible.

To attack illusion, one of the biographers says, is the highest service to people: one pays for it by bearing ingratitude humbly, and what one wins is the soul’s own worth, given back to many. What some sought by the sword and others by wealth he achieved with a humble heart, flooding the world with love for God — and a time is coming when every nation will sing his glory.

In June 1971 he visited Moscow. His stay behind the “Iron Curtain” lasted only three days, yet even in that time he gained a follower — Ananta Shanti Prabhu, who then began to preach to his friends. His disciples carried the work on. They preached in the countries of Eastern Europe; in 1976 Gopal Krishna

Goswami presented a set of his teacher's books each to the Lenin Library and the Tashkent Library, and that same year lectures on bhakti-yoga and the chanting of the Hare Krishna mantra were given at a research institute in Vladimir. The Soviet authorities persecuted the preachers — arresting them, confining them in psychiatric hospitals — until, with the changes in the country, the persecution ceased. Today, thanks to the preaching of his disciples, there are thousands of devotees in Russia, and "Our Teachers" sees in this the fulfilment of the prediction of Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura, who named Russia among the first countries that would accept Mahaprabhu's teaching with all their heart.

What touched George Harrison most in him was his humility. "This is the main point of everything he said: 'I am the servant of the servant of the servant'," recalled George Harrison. The Swami never laid claim to divinity, and Harrison admired his modesty and simplicity: "He was a perfect example of everything he spoke about." His influence on the world, in Harrison's words, is immeasurable: possessing nothing material, he made thousands of people devotees, and the movement he founded keeps growing even after his departure. The poet Allen Ginsberg confessed that in all their arguments he was always won over by the Swami's charm — deeply personal and yet wholly selfless, born of complete devotion to God. The Swami told him about his teacher, about Chaitanya and the chain of disciplic succession, and seemed to work on his translations day and night.

Harvey Cox, professor of theology at Harvard University, wrote that at a venerable age, heeding the call of his spiritual master, the Swami willingly took on all the hardships of the journey to America; there are thousands of teachers, but he was "one in a thousand, perhaps even one in a million". Shaligram Shukla, professor of linguistics at Georgetown University, said that for thousands of people he was an ideal embodied in a living being, answering the great questions of life by his very deeds. The historian of religion Thomas J. Hopkins noted that his example of devotion to God commanded attention — many young Americans followed him; he knew how to lead and was not afraid to set standards. "His voice was the voice of a seventy-year-old man. But when he spoke or sang, the whole atmosphere changed."

Humility and complete self-surrender to the Lord were joined in him with high demands on his disciples; yet his insistence, too, was for the Lord's sake — the active humility of one who carries out His will. Perfection and liberation can be reached even without humility, the biographer observes, but pure devotion stands on humility alone; Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami had both.

Books and the Name "Prabhupada"

However often he moved from place to place, he never stopped writing — essays, articles, books on the science of Krishna consciousness. Among his books are "Bhagavad-gita As It Is" (1968), "Teachings of Lord Chaitanya" (1968), "Krishna, the Supreme Personality of Godhead" (in Russian, "The Source of Eternal Pleasure", 1970), "The Nectar of Devotion" (1970), the "Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita" in seventeen volumes (1973–1975) and thirty volumes of the "Srimad-Bhagavatam" (1962–1977). In twelve years more than sixty volumes appeared; even in his lifetime they were translated into seventy-five languages and sold in tens of millions of copies, and in all, according to "Our Teachers", more than a hundred and fifty million of his books have been distributed around the world. He gave thousands of lectures, wrote thousands of letters and held thousands of conversations with disciples, admirers and opponents, and many eminent scholars and public figures acknowledged his contribution. Wherever he stayed, he acquainted people with Vedic literature and cared for his disciples. So the command he had once heard on the bank of Radha-kunda was being fulfilled.

In 1970 he founded the Bhaktivedanta Book Trust (BBT), which, according to "Our Teachers", has become the largest publisher of Vedic literature. R. Subramanyam of New Delhi wrote of his translation of the "Srimad-Bhagavatam" that amid unceasing travels and countless duties the founder-acharya of

ISKCON was translating this multi-volume Sanskrit work into English single-handed. “It is truly astonishing how he is able to do this alone… Is it not Vyasa Muni himself, reborn in our time to recast his old work in the world language of this age…”

His works became a support for others too. Bhakti Vidhan Mahayogi Swami, translating into English one of the biographies of the Lord’s associates, used the BBT edition of the “Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita” with Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami’s translation and commentary; he calls both Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami and Srila Sridhar Maharaj his beloved spiritual masters. He also writes that Lochana Dasa’s song “parama karuna pahun dui jana”, on the mercy of Nitai and Gaurachandra, was especially dear to Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami. He explained it thus: Nitai-Gaura are the sum and substance of every avatara, and the path They give is joyful — sing and dance.

“Prabhupada” was at first the name of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, and later Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami too was honoured with it. Some disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta disapproved of anyone but their guru being called so, but Sridhar Maharaj was very glad: “Yes, Prabhupada — he is fully worthy of this name.” Ordinarily, “Our Teachers” explains, devotees are addressed as “prabhu” and sannyasis as “prabhupada”, and the jati-gosvamis call all their gurus so, which is why India has many “prabhupadas”. But when Srila Bhaktisiddhanta preached Mahaprabhu’s teaching throughout India, the word took on a special meaning — “one who preaches the truth of Krishna consciousness throughout the world”; it was Srila Bhaktisiddhanta and Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami who gave it that meaning. Srila Prabhupada, as his followers have called him ever since, carried out his preaching in fulfilment of his guru’s will and spared no effort for it.

Shiksha-guru and Godbrother

The first letter the Swami wrote after arriving in America was addressed to Srila Govinda Maharaj — the same Gaurendu who had once carried “Back to Godhead” from door to door in Calcutta. The Swami had received two issues of the journal “Gaudiya Darshan”, which Sridhar Maharaj had begun to publish — while still in Mathura he had heard of the plan from Sripad Keshava Maharaj — and he was overjoyed. Everything that happens in the Math, he wrote, is possible only through Govinda Maharaj’s energy, and now it is clear why Sridhar Maharaj has bestowed all his mercy on him. The article “Chhalar Pathe” struck him as both beautifully written and deep: in time, the Swami wrote, Govinda Maharaj would probably become “the greatest transcendental humorist in the history of journalism”. “For me you will forever remain one of my most beloved sons.” And in a letter to Sripad Goswami Maharaj he called the start of the journal beyond all praise and added that Sridhar Maharaj had a fine assistant in the young Govinda Maharaj.

Great souls, says the “Bhagavad-gita” (10.9), find joy and bliss in talks about Krishna — “tushyanti cha ramanti cha”; such was the life of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami too. He always sought the company of his senior Godbrothers, and above all of Sridhar Maharaj. Returning to India in 1967, he stayed with him in Navadvipa, at the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math, and took part in the celebration of his Vyasa-puja. He wrote to one of his disciples: “Yesterday we arrived in Nabadwip-dham. The ashram where we are now staying was founded by one of my Godbrothers. It is spacious and wonderful here. My Godbrother B. R. Sridhar Maharaj has given us a whole house. He has also agreed to cooperate with our society. We shall celebrate his birthday, and our brahmacharis will learn how to celebrate the birthday of their spiritual master.” At that time the Swami offered Sridhar Maharaj the presidency of his young society, ISKCON; and, as Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled, “until his very last days in this world” the Swami wished Sridhar Maharaj to head ISKCON.

At that Vyasa-puja Achyutananda, a disciple of the Swami, saw his teacher deep in conversation with Sridhar Maharaj. Afterwards he asked what they had been speaking about, and heard: “If I tell you, you

will faint. Sridhar Maharaj is an extraordinarily exalted soul!"

All his life Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami deeply revered and trusted Sridhar Maharaj, and disciples to whom he could not give direct guidance he sent into his care. To one of them, Hrsikesa, he wrote from Los Angeles on 31 January 1969: "If you are actually serious to take instructions from a siksa guru, I can refer you to one who is most highly competent of all my god-brothers. This is B.R. Sridhara Maharaja, whom I consider to be even my siksa guru, so what to speak of the benefit that you can have from his association… When I was in India, Acyutananda, Ramanuga, and myself, with others, lived with Sridhara Maharaja… Leave Vrindaban, live peacefully with Sridhara Maharaja… and thereby you will be spiritually enlightened." (Letter to Hrsikesa, 31 January 1969) On his advice one of his first disciples, B. A. Sagar Maharaj, accepted the guidance of Sridhar Maharaj — and later received sannyasa from him as well. And Sripad B. B. Avadhut Maharaj relates that the Swami, foreseeing how his disciples would need higher guidance after his departure, advised them to turn to Sridhar Maharaj.

The compilers of Srila Sridhar Maharaj's book "Sri Guru and His Grace" confirm this: Swami advised his senior disciples to consult Sridhar Maharaj if they needed higher spiritual authority after his disappearance, and on more than one occasion he said, "I consider Srila Sridhar Maharaj to be my siksa-guru, instructing spiritual master, so what to speak of the benefit that others can have from his association."

What he meant by the word "shiksha-guru" is best explained by his own commentary on the "Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita". Krishnadasa Kaviraja writes: "I know my instructing Guru as Krishna's personal form. The Lord manifests Himself in this world in two forms: within, as the Supersoul in every heart, and without, as the best of Vaishnavas, the saintly teacher." (CC, Adi 1.47) The instructing teacher is Krishna Himself, Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami explains; Krishnadasa Kaviraja speaks of two kinds of instructing teachers — the liberated soul wholly absorbed in meditation on devotional service, and the one who awakens the disciple's spiritual consciousness by proper instructions. There is no difference between the Supreme Lord who gives shelter and the initiating and instructing teachers, and one who foolishly distinguishes between them commits an offence.

Sridhar Maharaj, for his part, understood and admired him as no one else did. "What our Swami Maharaj has done is a miracle!" he would say. "What Bhaktivinoda Thakura conceived, Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Thakura began to put into practice. And we see that through Swami Maharaj, at the end of his life, this plan has been fulfilled so completely. We are happy, we are glad, we are proud of it!" With tears in his eyes and a trembling voice the Swami replied: "All by the grace of Guru and the Vaishnavas… Therefore I want Sridhar Maharaj to give me his blessings, as he always has, and may Guru Maharaj help me to be able to do some service. All the success has come by his mercy. There is no merit of mine here." He himself, the Swami said, had no qualification at all — and he recalled the words of Srila Narottama Dasa Thakura from the "Prema-bhakti-chandrika": "chhadiya vaishnava-seva nistara payechhe keba" — who has ever found deliverance without serving the Vaishnavas? And Sridhar Maharaj said more than once: "Bhaktivedanta Swami Maharaj has cut a tunnel through the mountain of the Western ego!"

When in India, the Swami sometimes stayed at Sridhar Maharaj's Math in Navadvipa, and Sridhar Maharaj sometimes visited him in Mayapur, at the "Chandrodaya Mandir" — always together with Srila Govinda Maharaj. On 17 March 1973, at the opening of that ISKCON temple, the "Mayapur Chandrodaya Mandir", they sat together on one vyasasana; a photograph survives: the two of them on the vyasasana, and Srila Govinda Maharaj speaking into the microphone. It was then that the Swami recalled Allahabad in 1930 and the years when Sridhar Maharaj had lived in his house (this speech is told of above).

Srila Govinda Maharaj spoke that day at the request of Sridhar Maharaj, who was unwell. He began with the verse of Raghupati Upadhyaya “kam prati kathayitum ishe…”, which Krishnadasa Kaviraja quotes as well: “To whom shall I tell it, and who will believe me, that the Supreme Absolute Truth is the beloved of the young cowherd maidens in the groves by the Yamuna?” (CC, Madhya 19.98) This verse he applied to the Swami: “Who will believe me that Srila Swami Maharaj, whom we formerly knew as Abhay Babu, a regular participant in the programmes of the Sri Gaudiya Math and a householder occupied with family cares and business affairs, has now become a world acharya, known everywhere? He has spread Krishna consciousness over the whole planet, accomplishing the most impossible of all impossible deeds.”

Sridhar Maharaj later related that Govinda Maharaj called Srila Bhaktisiddhanta an extraordinary personality through whom Mahaprabhu wished to preach His teaching: he had many worthy followers, but for preaching in the West he chose Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami, and the Swami accomplished this task wonderfully. Govinda Maharaj also said that the Swami accepts Sridhar Maharaj as his shiksha-guru and regards Govinda Maharaj himself as a son. “In reply Swami Maharaj confirmed: ‘All that Govinda Maharaj has said is true. I love him as my own son, and his Gurudeva, Sridhar Maharaj, I regard as my shiksha-guru.’ He glorified me, calling me ‘Om Vishnupad’,” Sridhar Maharaj recalled. Thus, before many Godbrothers and thousands of devotees, the Swami publicly called Srila Govinda Maharaj his dear son. “At that time he was a Guru of world stature,” said Srila Govinda Maharaj. “For me this is a great mercy and a rare good fortune.”

Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami always loved Govinda Maharaj with a father’s love: for four years they preached together, and the Swami himself taught him the Vaishnava scriptures and the mridanga and looked after his health and well-being.

The Last Meeting and Departure

However much the Swami asked him, Sridhar Maharaj never once went abroad to preach. He explained this himself: to become a “big man” was not in his nature; his life was reflection on spiritual matters and talks on the scriptures in the circle of close devotees.

In March 1977, shortly before his departure, the Swami came to see him in Navadvipa; their conversation was recorded. “I do not know how much longer I shall last, so I have come to see Sridhar,” the Swami said. “How wonderful it is when the Lord’s will is fulfilled through someone,” Sridhar Maharaj responded. And the Swami began to ask him to settle at the ISKCON temple in Mayapur: “Srila Prabhupada [Srila Bhaktisiddhanta] always wanted you to preach. More than once he said to me: ‘Why don’t you bring him out?’… Srila Prabhupada spoke of you as one of the most remarkable preachers. I want to travel everywhere with you.” He promised to rent for Sridhar Maharaj any lodging he might wish, or to live together with him in the house his disciples were building for him — with a lift and a car — while Sridhar Maharaj could visit his own Math whenever he liked. While the Swami himself was travelling, his disciples would practise under Sridhar Maharaj’s guidance. “If you are near, it will be a great support for me. Sometimes I need to consult someone, but I have no one who could give good advice, and I need it very much… So, Maharaj, please order me — and I shall arrange everything… And that planetarium too will be built under your direction. I should like to unite Indian culture and American money. It will be for the good of the whole world.” “Yes, while I have strength, while I live, to fulfil the desire of Prabhupada [Srila Bhaktisiddhanta]…” Sridhar Maharaj replied.

The planetarium had long been Sridhar Maharaj’s own dream. He dearly loved Srila Sanatana Gosvami’s “Brihad-bhagavatamrita” and wished to build an exhibition where dioramas would show the planetary systems of the spiritual world described in that book and Krishna’s abode, Goloka Vrindavana. Having no means to do it himself, he offered the work to the Swami, who took it up with

enthusiasm: “The planetarium will be built under your guidance.” But Sridhar Maharaj did not move to Mayapur. “At that time I did not think I would live longer than he,” he explained later, “and so I promised to come to Mayapur as far as possible.”

Once, troubled by his illness, Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami wrote to Srila Govinda Maharaj: “I know that I still have many duties in the Western world and many things that I must do. But I feel that my time is coming to an end, I shall soon die, and I would like to leave my body in Vrindavana. So please ask Srila Sridhar Maharaj what I should do: should I go to Vrindavana or stay in the Western world?” Govinda Maharaj put the question to his guru, and Sridhar Maharaj dictated the reply: “Wherever you are, there is Vrindavana. Krishna is always with you and will always come to your aid. And if you should have to leave your body in New York, it will mean that Vrindavana has come to you in New York — have no doubt.” Later the Swami wrote: “The instructions of Sripad Sridhar Maharaj I keep in my very heart. Always and in everything he is my well-wisher. Certainly, after the departure of Prabhupada [Srila Bhaktisiddhanta] I should accept his guidance. And he has told me to stay in this country for good!” Another account of the same letter says that he accepts Sridhar Maharaj’s instruction “on my head”.

Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami left this world on 14 November 1977, on the Gaura Chaturthi of the month of Damodara, in Vrindavana, for which his heart had so longed[4]. A Vaishnava’s departure is no worldly death: having fulfilled the mission given by his guru, he entered the eternal pastimes of the Lord, Whom he had served all his life.

Shaktyavesha-avatara

After the Swami’s departure Sridhar Maharaj said: “I regard him as a shaktyavesha-avatara. This is attested by his writings composed during the voyage across the Atlantic, and by what he was able to do in the West. To the extent that he gave himself to Krishna, keenly felt his dependence on Him and was free from any desire other than the instructions of his Gurudeva, to that extent Krishna responded and descended to help him.” In the “Prayer to the Lotus Feet of Krishna”, Sridhar Maharaj went on, the Swami says that good fortune will come only when Srimati Radharani is pleased. Seeing in his guru, Srila Sarasvati Thakura, the embodiment of Radharani, and in his command a service to Her, he humbly confesses himself unworthy of that service and therefore asks Krishna to serve his guru. “He dedicated himself entirely to his teacher’s cause and prayed to Krishna so sincerely, wishing to fulfil the will of his Gurudeva, that a special divine power descended to help him… Therefore he is a shaktyavesha-avatara.” Srila Govinda Maharaj passes on other words of his guru about him: “An ordinary man could not have created such a Mission in just five years.”

Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami himself often repeated that no one can preach Krishna consciousness without being empowered by Krishna: “In the age of Kali the spiritual practice is the chanting of Krishna’s holy names. Without receiving Krishna’s sanction for it, no one can teach sankirtana.” (CC, Antya 7.11) His greatest achievement, “Our Teachers” says, is that he spread Krishna consciousness throughout the world and founded the International Society for Krishna Consciousness, which he charged with carrying Mahaprabhu’s message further — and only one whom the Lord had endowed with special mercy could do this. The biographer mentioned earlier likewise sees in him a shaktyavesha-avatara — an envoy invested with a special power of the Lord — and calls him “nityanandavesha”: the power of Sripada Nityananda Prabhu worked through him. To his followers, he adds, Srila Prabhupada was father and friend.

Sridhar Maharaj composed for him a pranama-mantra, which is recited daily at the services in the centres of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math. It begins with the words “namah om vishnupadaya krishna-preshthaya bhutale / swami sri bhaktivedanta prabhupadaya te namah”. Its meaning is this: obeisance to Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada, dear to Krishna, who came to the earth; taking his

guru's instruction upon his head, he appeared as an incarnation endowed with divine power, and by the Hare Krishna mantra delivered both West and East; he is the best of world acharyas, the image of divine mercy, who gave the world the sweetness of the "Srimad-Bhagavatam" and the knowledge of the "Bhagavad-gita"; he serves Sri Gaura, Sri Rupa and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati and, like a bee, clings to the lotus feet of Radha and Krishna[5].

Legacy

Just after his disappearance his senior disciples came to Sridhar Maharaj and asked his advice on how to guide the International Society for Krishna Consciousness; excerpts of these conversations entered the book "Sri Guru and His Grace". "The disciple is like a lotus," Sridhar Maharaj told them. "The spiritual master is like the water around the lotus… Your late gurudeva's position is like water and Krishna is like the sun": as long as the lotus floats on the water, the sun nourishes it, but without water that very sun will burn it. Before them, too, he glorified Swami Maharaj. To go with the Holy Name to every village was the design of ISKCON: "That was the aim of Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada, and we understand and appreciate that." "Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada went the length and breadth of the world with Krishna consciousness. The fact that you have all come here is due to his earnestness." Swami, he said, had laid stress among the Westerners on devotion to Nityananda and "distributed the key widely" to the treasures left in the scriptures. Those who had received the Holy Name from Swami and the gayatri from one of his disciples he advised to honour first of all Prabhupada, "who is the nama-guru, the guru of guru", and then the diksha-guru. And when a devotee asked why the disciplic succession in the "Bhagavad-gita As It Is" contains only thirty-eight names, though the system is fifty centuries old, Sridhar Maharaj answered that our succession "follows the ideal, not the body": it is a succession of instructing spiritual masters, and only the great stalwarts of the line are named in it. In the chart of the disciplic succession printed in the same book, the name of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami stands in brackets beside that of Srila Sridhar Maharaj, after Srila Bhaktisiddhanta.

Speaking of the spiritual revolution, Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled that the teachings of Buddha and Shankara needed a long time before people accepted them, whereas Srila Swami Maharaj presented Krishna consciousness to the whole world in just a few years, and in the swiftness with which this happened "there is undoubtedly something supernatural". So Mahaprabhu's prediction was fulfilled: "In every town and village throughout the world My holy name will be chanted." (CB, Antya 4.126) Through the Swami's preaching Krishna consciousness "swept over the whole world like a huge wave", and now, Govinda Maharaj said, a new wave has come — the preaching of Srila Sridhar Maharaj. Preaching is a war with maya, with Durga: Srila Swami Maharaj, Srila Sridhar Maharaj and others "created a revolutionary atmosphere", and the gates of Durga-devi's prison are broken — how else could people all over the world chant Hare Krishna?

On 26 October 2006, the day of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami's departure, Srila Govinda Maharaj gave a lecture in Saint Petersburg. The Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math now preaches throughout the world, he said, but this became possible only by the mercy of Srila Prabhupada, and the success in Russia is his achievement too. The movement of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, which has spread over the world, "has grown from the seed planted by Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada", and all the glory of preaching in the West has come by his mercy. On this day he is glorified in all the maths — in Navadvipa, in America, Mexico, England and other countries; the devotees of ISKCON, "members of our family", celebrate it too. "By the mercy of Krishna, by the mercy of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, the sankirtana movement begun in the Western world by Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada will never stop."

On this day, Govinda Maharaj related, the devotees cook Srila Prabhupada's favourite dishes — he was very fond of food cooked in ghee. "I remember how he scolded me: 'Why do you eat dry rice, without

ghee?! Be sure to eat it with ghee!'" But the young Gaurendu could not afford it: his usual breakfast was one paisa's worth of rice. In the first half of his life the Swami was a successful businessman, but Krishna wished him to become a pauper for the sake of spreading sankirtana, and "simple living and high thinking" came to him. "But his 'simple living' is not the same as what is usually meant by simplicity."

ISKCON, Srila Govinda Maharaj said, is a society that truly spreads Krishna consciousness: Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami founded it for the highest good of conditioned souls. When news came from all over the world that people were chanting Hare Krishna, Sridhar Maharaj rejoiced and always glorified the Swami, and the Swami often came and told him about his preaching. To carry Krishna consciousness across the world the Swami chose several leaders, was very proud of them, and named his successors the GBC — the Governing Body Commission; Govinda Maharaj warmly remembered his meetings with Bhavananda, Tamal Krishna and Achyutananda. He called both his gurus: Sridhar Maharaj was his diksha- and shiksha-guru, and Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami, "by the mercy of Srila Sridhar Maharaj", his shiksha-guru as well; both were his principal teachers. The Hare Krishna mantra, he said, was given to us by both of them, and they had no intention of creating sects: "There is no problem with ISKCON." Nor did he see any obstacle to his followers distributing the Swami's books, if the BBT agreed: everyone who honours both acharyas will be happy to see their books side by side.

Sripad B. B. Avadhut Maharaj says that the Swami, the only passenger of the "Jaladuta", brought the highest truths of the East to America[6], and that the first to accept his teaching were idealists who had challenged the Western consumer society. "In a mere ten short years the sankirtana movement swept over the whole world, returned to India and even penetrated the Iron Curtain of the socialist camp." The Swami preached tirelessly, set down what is most important in spiritual life in his commentaries on the Vedic books, and said that his teaching would spread in the world for another ten thousand years. And Sripad B. V. Goswami Maharaj, a preacher of ISKCON, sees in the books of Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada, the founder-acharya of ISKCON, the foundation of a broad, non-sectarian approach to preaching. He recalls an episode from the "Prabhupada-lilamrita": comparing two of his Godbrothers, Srila Prabhupada said that Sridhar Maharaj had depth and Keshava Maharaj a striving for breadth, and he asked his disciples to unite breadth and depth; this difficult task, following Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, he set before his followers. The path, though, is determined by Mahaprabhu Himself: Srila Prabhupada explains in his commentary on the "Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita" that some branches of Lord Chaitanya's tree wither in their time while others gain strength — according to which of them His shakti nourishes.

Many of his disciples have already been named in these pages. Let us name one more, Sripad B. S. Goswami Maharaj — his disciple by initiation, whose shiksha- and sannyasa-guru was Sridhar Maharaj; he wrote the book "Brothers" about the relationship of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami and Srila Sridhar Maharaj. The same relationship is the subject of the book "Our Teachers", published by our mission in honour of three acharyas — Srila Govinda Maharaj, Srila Sridhar Maharaj and Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami. Its conception, which belongs to Sripad B. A. Madhava Maharaj, was to glorify the greatest Vaishnavas of our time and reveal the depth of their spiritual relationship, and its aim — to bring them joy and help their followers unite in the service of Mahaprabhu's mission.

To all his followers he bequeathed not law but love. He gave to everyone, yet searched for the one who would truly understand his message. His inner form, the biographer says, is revealed only to those who accept the essence of his teaching and example: one can see his true nature only by his will. Deep realisation is the ability to apply spiritual truth to differing circumstances; an acharya does not freeze in time but flows out in love to everyone who reaches, however slightly, for pure devotion.

1. The date and place of his appearance are given in the book "Our Teachers" (Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math, ch. II.1); another biography does not give them. The day of the lunar calendar — the Krishna Navami of the month of Hrishikesha,

Nandotsava — follows our calendar (Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math); it agrees with the date of 1 September 1896.

2. “Our Teachers” speaks of this in different ways: in one place it says that Sridhar Maharaj and the young Gaurendu lived there “for several years”; in another Srila Govinda Maharaj recalls that the Calcutta branch of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math was housed in his home at his request “for ten years”. He himself, in his speech of 1973, says that Sridhar Maharaj lived in his house “for many years”.

3. “Our Teachers” speaks of the temple as “founded by Srila Rupa Gosvami”. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (4.285–290), Rupa Gosvami revealed the Deity of Sri Sri Radha-Damodara and gave Him to Srila Jiva Gosvami.

4. None of the biographies on which this article rests gives the day and place of his departure — only the year (1977). The day follows our calendar (Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math): the Gaura Chaturthi of the month of Damodara, which in 1977 fell on 14 November; the place is given from generally known information. The anniversary of which Srila Govinda Maharaj spoke also agrees with the calendar: in 2006 it was observed on 26 October.

5. The Russian translation of the mantra given in “Our Teachers” also says that he “descended into this world from Goloka itself” and that he is “the shaktyavesha-avatara of Nityananda Prabhu Himself”; these words are not in the Sanskrit text of the mantra. The idea that the power of Nityananda worked in him is expressed by another biography (see above).

6. The interview says “in the early sixties”. According to his diary and the biographies, he sailed for America in 1965.